

Rhodes Landfall

Jamie's track: the long scripts

Wednesday 30 September 2026 · Scarlet Lady · alongside 09:00, sails
18:00

01 • Who Counted

Cruise berth, Tourist Port (Akti Sachtouri)

Stand on the quay and find the walls to the west, across the harbour. That harbour was the merchant harbour of the ancient city, the open one, where the foreigners' cargo came in; the closed naval harbour with its secret sheds is round the corner to the north. And look south, along the low neck of land that runs toward the next port, Akandia.

In the year three hundred and five before Christ, with the fleet of Demetrius, son of Antigonos, already anchored off the town and his army camped outside the wall, the Rhodian assembly did the thing a city does when it is frightened and well organised: it counted. About six thousand citizens, and as many as a thousand foreigners fit to fight; the foreigners who were no use to the defence were sent out of the city, Diodorus says, to save food and to leave nobody inside with a reason to betray it. Then, before the first assault on the walls, the assembly voted what the city would owe the people its soldiers left behind. Slaves who fought bravely would be bought from their masters, freed, and enrolled as citizens. The fallen would be buried at public expense. Their parents and children would be fed from the public treasury. And, in Diodorus's words, "their unmarried daughters should be given dowries at the public cost", while their sons, on reaching manhood, would be crowned in the theatre at the festival of Dionysus and handed a full suit of armour. Burial, pension, dowry, arms: the four duties of a father, taken over by the state, with the circle drawn wide enough to take in slaves. The rich gave money, the craftsmen gave labour, and Diodorus says they competed to outdo one another. That is a welfare state written in advance of the casualties, and a city paying to marry off its dead men's daughters.

Diodorus calls this the best governed city of the Greeks. It lived on merchants sailing to Egypt, kept friendship with every king and fought in none of their wars, and Alexander had trusted it enough to deposit his will here. When the siege ended, in three hundred and four, the peace said the city was to be autonomous and ungarrisoned and to keep its own revenue, against a hundred hostages. No foreign soldiers, your own

taxes, your own laws, and one string attached: Rhodes must side with Antigonos in any war except a war on Ptolemy. That bundle is what sovereignty meant then, and it is worth holding onto all day. Among the first things the Rhodians did with it was say thank you. They built Ptolemy of Egypt a square precinct with colonnades a stade long, a hundred and eighty-five metres or so of covered walk, and, Pausanias says, gave him the name Soter, Saviour, and the name stuck. A small city, handing out names to kings. The third great bill of that war, after the dowries and the precinct, was a statue of their god, and that story begins a few streets in, upstairs in the Knights' hospital.

Now that neck of land to the south. A branch of the ancient city wall ran across it, with two horseshoe towers. After an earthquake in the second century after Christ the Rhodians gave up the old walls, and the abandoned rampart out here was buried under rubbish and slowly became a graveyard; the city went on shrinking for centuries after. So the ground between this harbour and the next is a late Roman cemetery on a rubbish-covered wall, and pushing the dead out to the edge of town is what nearly every regime here has done. The Knights made one exception, for their Grand Masters, who were laid under the floor of a church whose foundations you will pass this morning.

The counting never stopped. In April of eighteen eighty-six an Oxford geographer, Henry Tozer, was rowed ashore at Rhodes by two Turks, two Greeks and a Jew, and called them "a crew that well represented the nationalities which inhabit the place". In twenty twenty-five the port counted five hundred and forty-seven thousand cruise passengers, sixth among the harbours of Greece, and with three million visitors a year in all, the Athens press reached for the verb sinking. You are one of today's count. The harbour is still where this city works out who is here, and what it owes them.

The next track meets you at the wide arch in the sea wall, the Gate of the Virgin. Wait outside it. At the arch you will be handed the four questions the whole day asks.

02 • Who Sleeps Inside

Gate of the Virgin (Pyli Panagias)

Stand in front of the arch, with the wall on either side of you, and look left, where the rampart runs south along the harbour toward the corner. Before you go through, take four questions with you, because you will be asking them all day: who decided, who paid, who could own, and who could sleep inside these walls. Every power that has held Rhodes since the Knights has kept the walls, and every one of them rewrote the answer to the last question.

Start with the stretch to your left. The Knights of Saint John called it the Jews' Wall, because it curved round the Jewish quarter, and the Jewish quarter begins just inside this gate; you will come back to it before lunch. In fourteen eighty, with the Ottoman guns pounding this south-eastern corner of the town, Grand Master d'Aubusson had the Jews' houses behind the wall pulled down for building stone. The Order's ships also brought home Jewish captives taken at sea, two or three thousand of them, and kept them as slaves to work on these fortifications. The Jewish Virtual Library finishes that story in one flat sentence: in fifteen twenty-two, these captives helped the Turks conquer the fortress. So the stone beside you was partly built by people who slept inside these walls only because they were kept there as slaves, and partly betrayed by them.

Gates here are named by whoever holds the keys. The Knights named theirs mostly for saints; the townspeople named them for where they led. The Italians opened or reopened three in their three decades, one of them the gate the guidebooks say Suleiman rode in through in fifteen twenty-two and then had sealed behind him, though the same guidebooks admit the Knights had bricked it up themselves twenty years before he came. The Italians took the story at its word anyway and reopened it on the four hundredth anniversary of the conquest, which is a sentence in stone if ever there was one. And the one you are standing at was cut by the Greeks, the last power to hold the keys, and named not for a saint or a road but for the ruined church beside it.

And who decides today? The archaeologists keep watch from inside, from an office on the Street of the Knights, and the state's own tourist board insists the place is not a museum but a living, inhabited settlement. It is also a settlement whose biggest landlord is the state. The Ministry of Culture owns some three hundred and sixty-five buildings inside these walls, fifty of them on that one street, and it has started letting them out by tender, the first seven two summers ago. The minister who signed the money for the cables and the squares said the point was to socialise the monuments, whatever that turns out to mean for the people living in them.

How many people sleep inside? Nobody can tell you. The guidebooks say about six thousand; a local travel firm says two and a half thousand; nobody has published a census figure for the walled area. What there is, since April this year, is a permit. A permanent resident may drive in only with a special pass, and there is an app for reporting anyone who cheats. That pass is now the badge of belonging, the way a curfew bell once was. And across the town this year the substitute teachers were being pushed out of their flats before the school year had ended, so that tourists could have them from May to September.

Walk through now. Your next track starts just inside, at the church with no roof on your left. The lane beyond it belongs to the neighbourhood, the oldest institution in the street, which keeps its plastic chairs out and watches who comes in.

03 · The Parish and the Lane

Our Lady of the Burgh (Panagia tou Bourgou)

Stand where the nave was and look up through the three apses at the sky. Then look at what is left of the side walls. This church was recorded with six burial chapels built against its south side and seven arched tombs set into its north wall. What still stands is the three vaulted apses above you and, the guidebooks say, parts of the chapels. This was not the Greek town's church. The Church of Rhodes says it was the heart of a foundation of the Order, served by the brothers themselves, and in the last hundred years before the siege probably the church of the Latin archbishop. In the southernmost chapel the excavators found forty-five people buried together with a hoard of coins, which they connect to the siege of fifteen twenty-two. The Grand Masters and the brethren of the Convent were buried up the hill in the Order's own church of Saint John. Something like a hundred of their epitaphs survive, by the archaeologist Anna-Maria Kasdagli's count, and they are remarkably alike. Mostly in Latin, some in French, and nearly every one says the same thing: here lies, then a name, an office and a date. These were men who had sworn never to marry and left no children. In nearly every other household on this island the remembering was done by kin. The Order had to make stone do it instead.

The Greek families who bury their dead in this town today keep a timetable rather than a tombstone. A memorial service on the third day, the ninth and the fortieth, then at three months and six, at one year and at three. For a widow or a daughter that is years in black and a regular walk to the grave with oil for the lamp and a candle, and it ends, as the anthropologist Loring Danforth described, with the bones lifted out of the ground. On Rhodes that happens at six or seven years rather than three, because, as the community president told a local paper in twenty eighteen, the island soil is slow to do its work. The bones are washed, boxed and shelved in the cemetery's ossuary, for a small yearly fee, and if nobody keeps paying they go to the common pit.

The dead are not the only thing that comes up from under this town in winter. From Christmas to Epiphany, Greek households say, the goblins come up from underground, where they spend the rest of the year sawing at the tree that holds up the world. On Rhodes, one local study says, they are called *kantharoi*. You keep them out with a fire that never goes out, a black cross on the door, and a colander on the step, because they must count its holes and cannot say the word three. On the sixth of January the priest comes round with his sprinkler of holy water and they run, crying, in the chant the folklorists wrote down, “Run, let us run, the mad priest is coming with his sprinkler.”

Now step back into the lane and read the other constitution, the one nobody wrote down. Find a cat on a step. It became, in twenty twenty-one, the legal responsibility of the municipality, and if one ear has a notch in it, a neighbour took the trouble: telephoned the town hall to register it, waited for the municipal vet to book a slot, and carried it to the clinic and back; or took it to the free spring campaign that a charity from Hannover has run here since twenty twelve, fifteen thousand cats by twenty twenty-one. An ancient Rhodian would hardly have known a house cat; the Greeks kept weasels for the mice. It is the Ottoman householder, for whom the cat was ritually clean and welcome indoors, who would recognise this lane best.

When you pass basil in an olive-oil tin, that is *vasilikos*, the royal plant, which Orthodox tradition holds grew where the Empress Helena found the Cross. Sixteen days ago, on the fourteenth of September, it was blessed on a tray under the cross and handed out in church, and the sprig you are looking at may be one of them. Two plastic chairs against a wall are not furniture forgotten outside. They are the household’s seat on the neighbourhood, the *geitonia*, which the anthropologist Renée Hirschon, working in a refugee quarter of Piraeus, found to be a social unit in its own right, with the street rather than the house as the women’s arena. And any washing strung across the lane is one thing on these facades that the town’s appearance rules never listed, and nobody seems to police it.

Follow the lanes toward the square with the fountain. The building there with the outside staircase was the Knights' courthouse, and the next track begins in the square.

04 • The Bell and the Light

Marine Gate (Thalassini Pyli)

Before you go through the gate, look back across the square to the building at its far corner, where Aristotelous street leaves it. That is the Castellania, the Order's courthouse, and its stair is the point: it climbs the outside of the front that faces that street, a court built to be seen from the square. At the top of the stair an angel holds two shields, the Order's plain cross and the arms of Grand Master Emery d'Amboise; a Gothic frame nearby carries the date fifteen oh seven. On that same south front three crocodiles serve as rain-spouts.

The Order's registers show who sat in judgment and how they lived. One of its judges for criminal cases, in fourteen fifty-three, was a man with a thoroughly Greek name, Nicholas Gorgostares, doctor of law, who went to the Grand Master meaning to marry the serf woman who had borne his two children, and had her freed and her and those children made Roman citizens. A judge of the Order, marrying a serf, petitioning his family into the town.

In February fifteen ten the Order wrote down its rules for the town. A bigamist was paraded through it facing backwards on a donkey, wearing a paper crown, and then rowed the galleys for two years. The Order's statutes also said that free women, their dependants and serfs could not board a ship without the Master's licence, and the captain who took them answered for it. People were an asset here, and were guarded like one. In May fourteen seventy-six the Genoese trader Tobias Lomelino was stopped trying to sail for Genoa with his wife and daughters, and then, being the man who had farmed the Order's customs, let go.

Then there was the night. By custom anyone in the streets after dark carried a light, and a bell marked hours when nobody was to move between quarters. On the eighth of March fourteen fifty-three a Jewish couple, Ezra and Rebecca, who had gone to the Grand Master to protest a forced loan, won a bull from Jean de Lastic. It freed them from the community tax, fifty florins a year in all, their own share four. And it let them cross between the Upper and Lower Jewish quarters even during

the hours of bellringing, and go out at night, lamp in hand, to a bath, a pharmacist or a doctor. Two people, a lamp, and a piece of parchment: that is what freedom of the streets looked like here.

Look up the bazaar street climbing out of the square. The Jews of Rhodes called it Arriva del Kadi, up at the Kadi's, because the Ottoman authorities sat at its upper end, and the Ottoman census of eighteen thirty-one lists, beside this very street, a quarter of forty-three souls named for the kadi, the judge. The Italians abolished the kadi's office on the twenty-ninth of March nineteen thirty. Today's market judge is the municipality's Directorate of the Medieval City and Monuments, with its office up on the Street of the Knights. Its appearance regulation, which the town was asking shopkeepers to obey in twenty fifteen, allows one sign per street, whatever that was meant to mean, neither oversized nor lit, goods racks no wider than seventy centimetres, and bans what it calls touting which internationally defames our tourist product. The man calling you to a table from that doorway is breaking a rule, and a Knight's castellan, a kadi and a municipal clerk would each recognise the idea of one. Three market judges in five centuries, all within a few minutes' walk of one fountain.

Now step under the arch of the Marine Gate and face the harbour. After the Knights left, the gates, this one among them, became the sunset filter. Henry Tozer, the Oxford geographer, who landed here in April eighteen eighty-six, put it in his book: "The gates of the city are closed at night, and no Christians are allowed to remain within the walls, so that the Greeks, who occupy shops there, are obliged to quit the place at sunset." Until about eighteen thirty-five they also had to be out by Friday noon, for fear the town would be retaken while every Muslim was on his knees at prayer. On a Greek island, the Greeks slept outside their own city.

Now turn back through the gate and follow the lane north inside the wall to Museum Square. The long building on your left was the Knights' hospital, and upstairs in it, waiting for you, is the face of a god.

05 · Our Lords the Sick, and the Price of a God

Hospital of the Knights (Archaeological Museum)

The long building filling the south side of this square is the Hospital of the Knights, begun in fourteen forty, finished in fourteen eighty-nine, and now the Archaeological Museum. Go in and up the great stair. The ward at the top is a hall fifty-one metres long, and along its two long walls are small vaulted cubicles set into the thickness of the masonry. Those, it seems, were privies. The beds here were curtained, with clean sheets, and a Czech pilgrim, John of Lobkowitz, here in fourteen ninety-three, noted that beside each one a door opened onto the balcony, with a privy of its own.

Further along the same floor, in the south wing among the Hellenistic sculpture, is a marble head of a young man with wild hair, over life size, a ring of holes drilled round his brow for metal rays. He is Helios, the sun, carved in the later second century before Christ, more than a century younger than the Colossus, from another statue. But he is the same face the city stamped on its coins from its first years onward, sun on one side, rose on the other. Keep that face. You will need it on the harbour this afternoon.

This is where the god gets paid for. Pliny says the Colossus took twelve years and cost three hundred talents, money from selling the siege engines King Demetrius abandoned when he gave up. The sculptor was Chares of Lindos, a Rhodian, pupil of Lysippus, Alexander's court sculptor. It stood seventy cubits, about thirty-three metres, bronze over iron, with stone packed inside to steady it; Pliny says few people could get their arms round its thumb. How they raised it nobody knows. The one surviving account, going under the name of Philo of Byzantium and written centuries after the statue fell, has the workmen burying each finished course in a mound of earth and casting the next on top, and scholars still argue whether that is memory or invention.

What that money meant in human terms is easier. A talent is six thousand drachmas. In the year Rhodes was founded, four hundred and

eight before Christ, the Erechtheion building accounts in Athens pay a drachma a day to citizen, resident foreigner and slave alike, a slave named Somenes fluting a column beside his master. At that rate the Colossus is about one million eight hundred thousand days of work, a crew of four hundred for twelve years. That is arithmetic, not evidence, but it tells you what the money mostly bought: twelve years of people.

The Knights ran this building on a different arithmetic. Their Rule has a chapter on how our lords the sick are to be received and served. A sick man is put to bed and fed as if he were a lord, before the brothers eat, and a third of every house's bread and wine goes to the poor in the hospital. The ward rules put doctors on the floor twice a day, one on night duty, a brother from every tongue on the rounds with them, and a scribe checking prescriptions were followed. No cards, no dice, no books but religious ones. The same pilgrim wrote that the sick here ate off silver. Two names survive from before the hall was finished. One account has the Master hiring a Jewish physician, Jacunda Gratiano, in fourteen forty-five, while these walls were going up, after an oath sworn on the Jewish scriptures. And on the twenty-second of December fourteen fourteen a Hungarian slave called Helena, who worked in the Order's infirmary, was freed in recognition of her services to the sick. One institution: a slave woman on the ward, a Jewish doctor, noble knights on rota, and the patient outranking all of them.

Before you leave, find a grave stele carved a little before three hundred and fifty before Christ: a seated woman, her maid opposite holding the jewel box. The inscription, in one English rendering, reads in part: if there is a highest praise in the world befitting a woman, with this died Kalliarista, daughter of Phileratos, for wisdom and virtue; for this reason her husband Damocles set up this stele as a memorial of love. Daughter of, wife of, mistress of. A Greek woman's whole legal world on one slab. Greek law only let a married woman keep her own name in nineteen eighty-three.

When you come out, turn left up the cobbled street. The inns along it were households with no women and no heirs, and they had to write down everything a family does by custom.

06 • A Household Without Heirs

Street of the Knights (Odos Ippoton)

Look at the doors as you climb. Every one of them opened on a household. The brothers of the Order lived either in the inn of their own nation or in houses of their own, and an inn was less a barracks than a college hall: one nation's common table, its chapel, its beds for men newly arrived from home. In thirteen forty-five there were about four hundred Hospitallers on Rhodes. On the eve of the last siege, in fifteen twenty-two, two hundred and ninety knights and about three hundred sergeants. The ruling caste of an entire island would have fitted into one parish church, and it was a household with no women, no children and no heirs.

That is why it needed a written constitution for the things a family does by custom. The Rule of Raymond du Puy, which the Pope had approved before eleven fifty-three, told each brother to claim nothing beyond bread, water and clothing; to sleep clothed, in linen or wool, never in fur or bright colours; and, at table, in the Rule's own words, let each one eat his bread in silence. A brother found at his death to have kept property of his own was shamed in public, beaten, and set forty days' penance on bread and water. Nobody was born into this family. A knight had to be the son of a knightly house, born in lawful wedlock, with proofs of nobility that grew stricter with every generation; a serving brother needed only to show he was not a serf. The historian Anthony Luttrell adds, a little drily, that many brothers, served by their slaves, lived comfortably here all the same. The town had its own slave market, and the Order's registers name slaves from Bulgaria, Russia and Circassia; Albanians carried off from their country by ship were to be sold, a ruling of fourteen sixty-one says, in Rhodes Town and not elsewhere. When peace talks with the Sultan Bayezid broke down in thirteen ninety-two, it was because the Turks asked for the right to trade slaves here too.

A household this size needs an income, and this one had a country. The Order had answered to the Pope alone since a bull of eleven thirteen, its head elected for life by the professed brethren; but only when it took

Rhodes, in thirteen ten, did it gain territory and begin to strike coins, the mark of a sovereign. The first Grand Master here, Foulques de Villaret, put himself on the silver kneeling barefoot before a double cross. Most of the money never came from Rhodes. It came down a pipe from Europe: every priory from Provence to England sent its surplus, the responsions, up this hill. In thirteen twenty-nine that was a hundred and eighty thousand florins a year, and the Venetian Marino Sanudo wondered aloud how a house with that income could not fit out two or three galleys. Nine years earlier it had owed more than half a million florins, mostly to the Pope's Florentine bankers, the Bardi and the Peruzzi.

The inns themselves ran on local money. A document of fourteen oh one records the chapel of Saint Dominic, inside the hospice of the Italian tongue, endowed by the Order's Admiral, Palamedo di Giovanni, with the income of two windmills. One of them stood on the harbour mole, where a single windmill still stands today. And before the Admiral had it, that mill belonged to two women, Eirene Stamatudine and Eirene Archondo. Women are all through the registers of this supposedly closed quarter. Sophia, daughter of John Diastrique, owned a two-storey hospice inside it. In thirteen forty-seven a Hospitaller sister, Margarita of Negroponte, held apartments near the cathedral and an oven she had built to bake bread for the poor. And in fifteen seventeen the Order was still paying a widow who lived inside the castle, Katherina tou Sinademi, one measure of wheat every month for herself and her seven children. A widow on a grain ration is a truer picture of this street than any coat of arms.

You know this arrangement already. Any Dodecanese village that lived through the last century on money posted home from Australia or America was running the Order's economy in miniature: a household on Rhodes kept alive by wages earned somewhere else, and in trouble the moment the pipe closed. Under the arcade at the top, look left to the school. That is where this household buried its princes, and where you will hear what became of their coffins.

07 • One Coffin, Two Burials

Site of St John of the Collachium (the vault that exploded)

From the top of the street, look left, to the long, low neoclassical school up on its terrace, with the clock tower rising behind it. In front of it, below the terrace wall and behind a railing, is a patch of dug-out ground: stubs of foundation, and one broken piece of wall still standing higher than your head. That is all that shows of the church of Saint John of the Collachium, the Order's own church: the church of a monastic state that chose its prince by vote, and buried him here.

Choosing came first. A Grand Master was elected for life by the professed brethren, and in later years by a college drawn from the tongues whose inns you have just walked past. On paper that made him a prince answerable to nobody but the Pope. In practice, the Pope was enough. In thirteen seventeen knights who had had enough of Foulques de Villaret's spending and high-handedness tried to kill him. He fled to Lindos, and the Order elected Maurice of Pagnac in his place. Pope John the Twenty-second refused to recognise Pagnac, pressed Villaret to resign, and by June of thirteen nineteen a third man, Helion de Villeneuve, had the office. One pope, two masters unmade, a third made. Two centuries on, the Order elected Guy de Blanchefort while he was still away in the west, and he died at sea before he could reach the island he had been chosen to rule. The office did not wait for the man; Fabrizio del Carretto was chosen in his place. The laws themselves came from the Chapter General, the assembly of the whole Order, which alone could make the statutes that bound it. A state with no dynasty, and so a state that had to write down what a family does by habit.

These men had no descendants. No family would boil wheat for them on the Saturday of Souls, as Rhodian families still do for their dead; the Order said its masses, and stone did the rest, and the Order was not fussy about whose stone. Cecil Torr, writing in eighteen eighty-seven, says the tombs of Robert de Juilly, who died in the thirteen seventies, and Jacques de Milly, who died in fourteen sixty-one, were ancient Greek sarcophagi. Juilly's white marble coffin was later turned by the

Ottomans into the basin of a public fountain, and then acquired by the Musée de Cluny in Paris, where four of the masters' monuments are now. Milly's was opened again three years after him for an infant prince of Savoy, a son of Queen Charlotte of Cyprus, who had lived less than a month; his epitaph was cut beneath the master's. Carretto, the last master to die on Rhodes, lay under a window on this side, the street side, beneath a slab whose Latin called him restorer of the city and for seven years its ruler for the public good, and said that he lay here, fifteen twenty-one. Where the bones themselves went, nobody wrote down.

Torr adds one detail. A vaulted gallery ran from this church across to the Palace, over the top of the street where you are standing, and in it, he says, every knight had to perform gun-drill at least once a week. Prayer on one side, the master's hall on the other, and the covered walk between them for practice with a gun.

The Order left in fifteen twenty-two and the church became the town's great mosque, and in eighteen fifty-six lightning reached gunpowder stored in the cellars of its old bell tower and took the church, and at least two hundred lives, with it; Carretto's tomb was looted in the wreck. Henry Tozer, who came through thirty years later, recorded that the Turkish authorities had not known the powder was there: a garrison sitting on a magazine nobody had inventoried, until lightning found it. The rubble went into a Muslim school, rebuilt in this neoclassical shape about eighteen ninety-eight. It was one of the last Turkish-language schools on the island; the military junta closed it in nineteen seventy-two and renamed it the Thirteenth City Primary School, and by twenty fifteen a human rights report was describing it as bare walls. Look for yourself and see how it has fared since.

Now turn right, to the gate between the two horseshoe towers: the Palace of the Grand Master. Your next track begins in its courtyard.

o8 • The Priest Who Named the Year

Palace of the Grand Master

You are standing in the forecourt of the Palace of the Grand Master, on a small hill at the top of the Knights' quarter. Look at the two horseshoe towers of the gate, and at whatever flag is flying over them; I want to tell you who has sat on this hill. The best current guess, still untested by any excavation, puts the sanctuary of the sun god Helios under your feet; others put it on the acropolis to the west. So why did a trading city choose the sun?

The answer is a poem. In four hundred and sixty-four before Christ Pindar wrote an ode for a Rhodian boxer, Diagoras, which the Rhodians, ancient commentators say, kept in letters of gold in Athena's temple at Lindos. In it Helios is away when the gods divide the earth, and nobody draws a lot for him. He refuses a re-draw and makes Lachesis, the Fate who allots, swear that an island he can see rising from the sea will be his alone. Rhodes is not conquered or colonised; it rises already belonging to one god, by oath. A title deed. The same poem says the sun's sons hurried uphill to be first to sacrifice to newborn Athena and forgot the fire, and that Zeus rained gold on them anyway and Athena gave them every art of handicraft. Diodorus says the rite was still fireless in his day. A city whose founding story says craft was a gift from heaven will one day build the biggest statue in the world.

When Lindos, Ialysos and Kameiros merged into one state in four hundred and eight before Christ, each kept its own gods, so the new state needed one who belonged to all three and to none. Helios was the answer, and his priest became the man the year was named after, appointed, it seems, in turn from each of the three old cities. Every decree and contract was dated in the priesthood of so-and-so. So was every jar of wine that left the harbour, stamped with the priest's name and the month, which is why the list survives in clay: two hundred and sixty-six priests, beginning around three hundred before Christ and running for two and a half centuries. Most of that list was read off more than a hundred and forty thousand broken handles in Alexandria alone.

A jar handle dug up in Jerusalem can be dated to within a year or two by the name on it. Six communities on the mainland opposite dated their documents by him. Sovereignty, on Rhodes, was a calendar, exported by the shipload.

Now the statue: the Colossus, the bronze Helios put up after the great siege. Its dedication says the people of Dorian Rhodes raised it when the wave of war was laid to rest, and ends with a line to hear on this hill: for to those who spring from the race of Heracles dominion is a heritage both on land and sea. That is Pindar's oath again, raised thirty-three metres high. The nearest thing to its face is the Helios head you saw in the museum, a century or more younger, wind in the hair, holes drilled for metal rays.

Then watch who sat here. After Arab raids in six hundred and fifty-four and six hundred and seventy-three, the hill was walled as a Byzantine citadel. After twelve hundred and four a local magnate, Leo Gabalas, called himself Caesar and Lord of Rhodes and the Cyclades and struck coins reading Caesar on one face and Servant of the Emperor on the other: sovereignty hedging its bets. Then the Order, for two centuries. In eighteen eighty-one a history of the island by Edouard Biliotti and the Abbé Cottret described three storeys of vaulted storerooms down to the moat, a courtyard pierced with cisterns still holding grain as the Knights had done, and a convict prison of about two hundred and fifty men. The Italians rebuilt it as a holiday house for their king and for Mussolini; look for the large plaque near the entrance that still carries his name. And in December nineteen eighty-eight Andreas Papandreou hosted the European Council here, so a house rebuilt for a king and a dictator ended by seating Europe's heads of government. Who sits on the hill changes; the hill decides nothing and hosts everyone. Look again at that gate.

When you are done, go out through the small gate on the west side of the forecourt to the great gate beyond it, and look up for a date carved in Roman numerals.

09 • Receipts on the Wall

D'Amboise Gate (the dragon's head)

You are under the arch of the d'Amboise Gate. Walk through to the outer side, facing the bridge and the moat, turn round and look up over the arch. An angel holds two shields up there. One is the plain cross of the Order. The other is Emery d'Amboise's own arms, with his name and the Roman numerals for fifteen twelve cut in the marble below them, split in two around the angel's robe. He was Grand Master until fifteen twelve, and the gate was finished in the year he died.

Here is how to read a shield on a Rhodes wall, because it is not decoration. It is a receipt, a date-stamp and a claim of jurisdiction. Henry Tozer, in eighteen eighty-six, wrote down what he saw: the escutcheons over the dwellings or the gateways, denoting either the possessor or the person by whom they were erected, but all of them containing the cross of the Order. The family shield says who paid. The plain straight-armed cross says under whose sovereignty. On the Marine Gate, the twin-towered one you looked at from Hippocrates Square, the set grows to three, with the King of France in the middle. Because the masters' reigns are known, a shield dates a wall the way a reign dates a coin. And notice who is allowed one: a grand master, a king, a pope, a tongue of the Order, now and then one of its great officers. Never a sergeant-at-arms, whose entry requirement was simply not to be a serf.

What each regime did with the last one's marks tells you about the regime. Ettore Rossi, the historian of the fifteen twenty-two siege, says the Turks left the coats of arms, the gateways and the inscriptions almost intact. Nearly four centuries of sultans did not chisel off the Knights' shields; they added wooden balconies, plaques in Arabic script and fountains. The Italians stripped the balconies off the inns in nineteen sixteen and cleared away the Ottoman houses that had grown up against the walls. The Muslim conqueror kept the Christian shields. The Christian coloniser kept them too, and pulled down the Muslim houses that stood in the way of its plan.

Now the older institution under all of this. Local tradition says a dragon's head hung over this gate until the eighteen thirties, the trophy of a knight said to have killed a beast in a marsh under the hill to the west. The knight is a story for another day. Why does a city hang a trophy on its gate at all? The Greeks who lived here first had an institution for it, what scholars call hero cult. Diodorus has one: Phorbas, a Thessalian sent for by Apollo's oracle to clear the island of snakes, and given a hero's honours when he died. That phrase has a shape: a tomb, a sacrifice there every year, sometimes games. Then there was Althaemenes, a prince of Crete. An oracle said he would kill his father, so he fled here and founded the temple of Zeus on Attavyros, the island's highest mountain. His father came looking for him and landed by night with a few men. There was a fight in the dark with the islanders, Althaemenes ran out to help them, and the spear he threw killed his father, whom he did not recognise. When grief had finished him the Rhodians, on an oracle's orders, gave him a hero's honours too. The old commentator on Pindar adds that the temple on the mountain kept bronze bulls that bellowed when disaster was coming: an alarm system in the form of a cult object. That is how a hero gets a job. He clears the land or founds the shrine, he dies, and the city turns his death into an annual obligation it can put in the calendar.

Look at where those heroes came from. Phorbas from Thessaly. Althaemenes from Crete. Danaus, who put in at Lindos on his way from Egypt with his daughters. Nearly every founder in this island's stories arrived from somewhere else; only the Sun's own line, his sons and the grandsons who named the three old cities, were born here. A port wrote its cosmopolitanism into its origins, and the Knights did the same with a trophy over a gate: this is who cleared the land, and this is who holds it now.

The hero still has a job: the island's airport is named Diagoras, after a boxer who won at Olympia two and a half thousand years ago.

Back through the gates to the Palace forecourt. At noon the iron gate opens and you can walk on top of the walls.

10 • The Earthquake Ledger

Walls walk: iron gate on the Palace forecourt

You are walking south along the top of the wall, with the moat on your right, planted now as gardens, and beyond it the roofs of the suburbs. This is the chapter of the Colossus that is about money.

Around two hundred and twenty-six before Christ an earthquake threw down the Colossus and most of the walls and dockyards. The Rhodians sent envoys to the cities and kings of the Greek world, and Polybius says the adroit policy of the Rhodians converted this misfortune into an opportunity: they spoke of the disaster so gravely that they were not only overwhelmed with presents but made the donors feel actually obliged for their acceptance of them.

He kept the list. From Syracuse, seventy-five talents of silver for oil in the gymnasium, fifty catapults, and a statue group of the People of Rhodes crowned by the People of Syracuse. From Ptolemy in Egypt, three hundred talents of silver, a million measures of grain, timber for twenty warships, and three thousand talents to raise the Colossus again, with four hundred and fifty builders. Gifts too from Macedon, from the kings of Asia, and from the cities, each according to its means. That is a state, itemised: walls, docks, ships, oil, meat for the gods, citizens recruited with cash. Polybius adds a sour moral for the kings of his own day, who expected thanks for four or five talents.

Then the twist. Ptolemy had promised three thousand talents for the statue, and paid a third of his cash down at once; the statue was never rebuilt. Strabo says only that in accordance with a certain oracle, the people did not raise it again; later tradition says it was Delphi, Strabo does not say. The assembly that had voted a wonder now voted, with a god's permission, to leave it on the ground, and nobody records the money going back. Piety and accounting were one department.

This wall has always sorted people. In eighteen eighty-six Henry Tozer found that it was forbidden to walk on the walls, and any one who stopped for more than a minute to notice an object was hailed by a sentry; to attempt to sketch was dangerous, since after the war with Russia

the garrison feared plans of the fortress. Your stroll was an offence in the eighteen seventies. Beyond the moat on the south side Tozer saw an old Turkish cemetery where, he says, the bones of the besiegers who fell in the siege lie; the Italians turned those graveyards into parks.

The gate where you come down, the Gate of Saint John, was La Puerta de la Sividad to the Jews of the town, the city gate, and their funerals went out through it to the cemetery that began just outside. A caller cried *Pasa la misva*, the commandment is passing, and people in the street turned their faces away. In the late nineteen thirties the Italian governors cleared that ground for public gardens. Thousands of graves were moved to the Kallithea road, often paid for by relatives who had emigrated; the graves of about eighteen rabbis were moved at the community's cost; the graves nobody could pay for were destroyed, and two cenotaphs stand for them. About a hundred of the finest stones were built into the Palace behind you. The rest, the stones nobody could read, were laid in empty ground in the new cemetery and forgotten, until the restoration of nineteen ninety-seven uncovered them, fifty-eight years later. The oldest found so far, turned up only in twenty twenty-three, is Haim Provencal's, who died in thirteen sixty-three, under the Knights. Notice who paid, both times: kings for the walls, emigrant cousins for the graves. Rhodes is rescued by its neighbours and rebuilt with money from somewhere else, and it still is: dozens of families come back every July for the memorial services, from the cities their grandparents left for. Down the steps and five minutes north is a quarter that governed itself for four centuries and can be crossed in four minutes, and a synagogue courtyard with a fountain where the priests washed their hands.

11 • The Small Jerusalem

Kahal Shalom Synagogue and Jewish Museum

Kahal Shalom is two streets up from the foot of the wall. Go in through the door on Dosiadou street; the first thing inside is a courtyard. Find the plaque on its east wall, over the place where a fountain once stood. It is dated Kislev, five thousand three hundred and thirty-eight, which is fifteen seventy-seven. The fountain was for washing hands: the Kohanim, the congregation's priestly families, washed there before raising their hands to bless the room. Inside, look down: the floor is black and white pebbles, the craft that floors courtyards across the old town, Turkish and Greek alike. The women's balcony came only in the nineteen thirties; for three and a half centuries before that the women prayed in the side rooms; those rooms are now the museum.

The people who built this were later known as the small Jerusalem, and they had arrived on terms. A nineteen oh six encyclopedia repeats the tradition that the sultan gave the resettled families twenty years free of tax and a house free of expense. Greek-speaking Jews had been here since Roman times, four hundred of them by a twelfth-century traveller's count, until the Knights ordered them converted or expelled twenty years before the Turks came; what was left took on the Spanish rite.

What they made was a corporation of households. Their court, the Bet Din, handled ritual, business, family law, inheritance and crime. Rhodes bent one rule: a married daughter could inherit what the museum's own account calls a nice portion of her father's estate, though the law did not normally let daughters inherit beside brothers. Welfare ran through three funds: Bikur Holim for the sick and the dead, whose plaque of nineteen twenty-four still hangs at number four Vizantiou street; Ozer Dalim for the poor; and the Fundo Secreto, for the poor who would be shamed by being seen to receive. Schools were where the quarter argued with itself: in eighteen eighty-two the French vice-consul, Moses Franco, opened a school teaching Hebrew, Turkish and French, and after five

years the rabbis had it shut. The one that won, finished in nineteen oh four with Rothschild money, taught in French and took girls.

A household was several generations under the oldest man. On a Friday the bride's father led her with musicians down the wide street, and at her own door she said, with your permission, I want to go with my husband, kissed the mezuzah on the doorpost, and rice was thrown. Children were named, in the Sephardic way, for living grandparents, and cousins married cousins: fifteen surnames fill two thirds of the graves. A baby wore a pouch of garlic or salt, a gold coin and a blue bead against the evil eye, the eye the Greek church still keeps a prayer against, the bead a Turkish house hangs by the door.

In eighteen forty a Greek boy vanished. The Greek clergy and the European consuls pressed the governor, Yusuf Pasha; eight Jews were arrested, the chief rabbi Jacob Israel among them, one man was given five hundred blows, and the quarter was sealed for twelve days without food or water. Then Constantinople intervened: everyone acquitted that July, the governor dismissed for torture the empire had just forbidden, the sultan's own decree in November calling the charge a calumny.

Days before the deportation of July nineteen forty-four, a Torah scroll believed to have come from Iberia with the exiles went to the mufti, Sheikh Suleyman Kasiloglou, who, the Times of Israel reports, hid it under the pulpit of a mosque; it is in the National Library of Israel now.

When you come out, go to the square. It was La Kaye Ancha, the wide street, where the wedding processions passed; the street's old fountain stood here, and the seahorses are its replacement. The black column in the middle is the memorial: one thousand six hundred and seventy-three people were gathered here and marched to the harbour on the twenty-third of July nineteen forty-four. In June of this year the Rhodes court ruled that seventy-nine heirless houses and shops of the deported belong to the Greek Jewish welfare body; one registry area is called Synagogue Shalom, and some of those houses are around you. Lunch is three minutes away, on a quiet street off the bazaar, and the next track is about who feeds whom. It is Rob's birthday table.

12 • Who Feeds Whom

Lunch: Nireas, Sofokleous 22

It is Rob's birthday. You are under a grapevine on Sofokleous, and the loudest thing on the street is the cutlery. From three o'clock this quiet stops being manners and becomes the law: a police regulation of nineteen ninety-six forbids music and loud conversation from three until half past five, and today, the last day of September, is the last day of the summer rule. An Athens paper says the penalty can be a few months in jail. The silence is an institution, and so is the table: a Rhodian meal has always settled who feeds whom.

Start with a cake. On the twenty-seventh of August, at the church of Saint Fanourios a few lanes from here, it is mostly women who come, carrying trays of cakes and slips of paper with lists of names. The saint is asked to reveal what is missing, an object, a job, a spouse, a diagnosis, and the cake is the payment: oil and no eggs, an odd number of ingredients, seven like the sacraments, or nine. The priest blesses it and it is shared with at least nine people, with a wish that God forgive the saint's sinful mother, which is a folk touch the Church has never formally held. Pindar says the first Rhodians hurried up their hill to build Athena her altar and forgot the fire, and Diodorus adds that at Lindos her altar stayed fireless for centuries. Here is a fireless offering, still working, in a baking tin. The three nights of music behind the church, put on with a local association that calls itself the Knights of the Old Town, are a panigyri, the ancient word panegyris said the modern way: a whole community feasting at its sanctuary, with a new saint on the door.

The dead eat too. At every memorial, the third day, the ninth, the fortieth, on through the third year, the family brings kollyva, boiled wheat with pomegranate seeds, almonds and cinnamon, moulded into a mound the shape of a grave under powdered sugar. The priest blesses it and everyone present eats a spoonful. Wheat has paid for more than the dead here. About a hundred and sixty years before Christ, King Eumenes of Pergamon gave Rhodes two hundred and eighty thousand measures of grain, to be sold, the money lent out at interest, and the interest to

pay the schoolmasters. Polybius sniffed that a city so rich should not beg for its teachers' pay. Wheat into cash into teachers: hold that thought for the library at the top of the bazaar.

A few lanes east, in the Jewish quarter, the week ran on a different table. Thursday night the women started cooking for the Sabbath. On Friday, when the work was done, the family went to the Turkish bath, the banyo turko. Saturday night came stories of Djoha, the trickster the Turks knew as Nasreddin Hoca. At Purim children went house to house with plates of sweets and a blessing: may you live like fresh water, may your house be as full as an egg. At Passover the door was opened and the family sang out that all who are hungry should come and eat. This week is Sukkot, the festival of huts roofed with palm and myrtle, and among the community's own dishes is palamida, which is bonito, and it may well be on your plate today.

Now the kitchen. Last year just over a quarter of Greek hotels hired workers from outside the European Union, and the institute that counted them names housing as a main cause: the rooms a waiter might rent are let by the night to visitors. Giorgos Chotzoglou, who leads the tourism workers' federation, says only one hotel in ten and one catering business in twenty applies the collective agreement, that the worker is not a machine, and that the seasonal unemployment benefit needs a hundred insurance stamps from a single season. The person bringing your plate is doing arithmetic this week: did the summer give me my hundred. When Rob's track moves you on, it goes north and up the bazaar street, the one the Jews called up at the judge's, to the pink mosque. The next track starts under the minaret.

13 • The Endowment and the Clock

Roloi clock tower, Suleymaniye and the Ottoman library

In front of the rose-pink mosque, find the small domed fountain standing on eight columns. They were taken from buildings older than the mosque, and the water is not for drinking. It is for washing hands, face and feet before prayer, and the way it was paid for is the way most of this town was paid for.

An Ottoman town did not run a water department. It ran on endowments. A family would lock away shops or orchards for ever, name a trustee, and let the rents pay for a mosque, a fountain, a teacher, a soup kitchen. The Orthodox church of Rhodes, on its heritage website, says it plainly: to a Muslim, building a public fountain was a benefit for the soul. The foundations register for eighteen eighty-five counted on this island forty-four mosques, fifty water fountains and twenty cemeteries held that way. And exactly one library. It is the one across the lane, and it is still running.

Hafiz Ahmed Agha was born around seventeen forty in Asgourou, a village four kilometres south of here, and served two sultans as chief equerry. On the twenty-sixth of February seventeen ninety-two he signed his foundation deed in Istanbul, and the next year the library opened with eight hundred and twenty-eight manuscripts, the foundation says, and eight hundred and six still carry his seal. The rents still pay the bills, and the trustee today is his seventh-generation descendant, Tarik Tuten, who uses the Arabic word for an endowment, waqf, and says: “No other waqf like this, let alone a library, still exists under the original family’s care. It’s a miracle it survives.” The groundskeeper, Yusuf, has kept the courtyard for forty years on those rents.

The founder’s son, Ahmed Fethi Pasha, marshal of the imperial arsenal, put the clock tower you can see fifty metres up the lane, between eighteen fifty and eighteen fifty-two, and beside it a house for the timekeeper. A school followed the year after. The clock came from Edward Prior, Chambers and Company of London and drove all four dials. The timekeeper worked out the five daily prayer times from the sun, and the town

took its time from him. That is how an Ottoman town made time public: as a pious act, out of one family's rents. If you climb it with Rob for his birthday drink, you are climbing inside that act of piety, a tower built so that a whole town could agree what time it was.

Your address here was not a street. It was a mahalle, a neighbourhood named for the prayer-house at its centre, where the families who prayed together lived together. The census of eighteen thirty-one found twenty-three Muslim neighbourhoods and two Jewish ones inside these walls, some two thousand names on the rolls of the Muslim quarters alone, and the names are a social map: the Judge's quarter, the Bootmaker Ali Agha's, and the one called With Cupboards, after the wooden panelling the Ottomans fitted over the walls of an old church down by the Red Gate. The judge's court took crime and trade for everyone; for marriages and wills the Greeks went to their Metropolitan and the Jews to their rabbis, and the non-Muslims paid a poll tax in place of military service.

Now the unusual part. In nineteen twenty-three, when Greece and Turkey exchanged most of their Muslims and Christians by treaty, this island was Italian, and the same treaty said so. The exchange passed it by, and so did the protections written in for the Muslims who stayed in Greece. The island's Muslims simply stayed, and became Greek citizens in nineteen forty-seven. There are two to four thousand of them today. One mosque, Ibrahim Pasha, near where you ate lunch, is in regular use, licensed only in twenty nineteen; its caretaker's family has been here since fifteen twenty-six, and he says it gets crowded on Fridays. The call to prayer stays inside the building. Of six hundred plots the endowments held in nineteen twenty-five, the community says around sixty remain. And for decades, the anthropologist Kira Kaurinkoski found, official guides here were instructed not to mention the Ottoman past. Consider it mentioned.

When you are ready, the bazaar runs back downhill to the square, then north past the museum to Symi Square, where the only temple you can touch inside the walls lies in a fenced heap, in a city that once owned three thousand statues.

14 • A Second City of Clubs

Temple of Aphrodite, Symi Square (the Telchines)

Stop at the fence and look through it at the column drums and the low platform they fell from, a temple from the third century before Christ. The archaeologists give it to Aphrodite; notice where she was put: the trading harbour on one side of you, the old war harbour on the other. Put between two harbours, she was surely less the goddess of love than of safe landing. She is the first in a line of sea-guardians on this shore. Saint Nicholas of the sailors, in the fort at the mole's end, and the Virgin's cathedral on the waterfront across the harbour mouth from it, are the ones who came after her. The prayer changes; the shore does not.

The trading harbour filled this city with people who were in it but not of it. They could not vote, could not own land, could not be buried as citizens. So they built a second city out of clubs. Rhodes has left about two hundred of them in stone, and one Rhodian's name is attached to no fewer than twenty-three of them; he cannot have been at all the dinners. Many were named for gods, so there were Aphrodisiasts for the goddess in front of you and Haliasts for the Sun. One club's roll lists Ephesians, Antiochians and Alexandrians, a Phrygian and a Knidian, alongside several Rhodians.

What they did was pool money. In one hundred and eighty-five before Christ, in the cemetery south of this city, thirty-six members of a club of the Samothracian gods, Hermes and the Panathenaia bought a shared grave for about a thousand drachmas, and the stone says they promised to give voluntarily money for the price of the place, and they did pay. It is dated, naturally, by the priest of the Sun, Nikasagoras, whose name was that year's name across the island. A building fund from about ten years earlier lists Xouthos of Antioch at twenty drachmas and Dromon of Cappadocia at five, plus doors. The museum you were in this morning, whose square you have just crossed, keeps a stone on which a Phoenician called Abd-Melqart calls himself, in Greek, Heraclides of Citium. That is the immigrant experience in one object. The people in this city but not of

it today are the season's workers; last year more than a quarter of Greek hotels hired from outside the Union.

The year the city died politically was forty-two before Christ. Cassius, Caesar's assassin, came for it. The Rhodians chose to fight, and fell when sympathisers inside opened the small gates. Cassius took his seat on the tribunal and planted a spear beside it, summoned about fifty citizens by name and had them killed, and ordered all the gold and silver in the city brought to him, with death for anyone who hid it, a tenth to informers, and freedom to any slave who told. He emptied the temples too, the historian Cassius Dio says, with the exception of the chariot of the Sun, which is probably Lysippus's bronze Helios in his four-horse chariot. Who decided now? A Roman with a spear beside his chair.

What Rome left was a free city on paper, and the freedom was a dial. In the year forty-four after Christ the Rhodians lost it for impaling some Romans; nine years later a sixteen-year-old Nero won it back. The best witness to daily life under Rome is a visiting orator, a different Dio, who came to scold the Rhodians about statues. Pliny reports three thousand still standing here in his day, and when a Roman wanted the honour of one, the chief magistrate merely pointed his finger at the first statue that met his eyes, had the old inscription removed and a new name engraved. Then he holds up a mirror: your remaining silent as you watch the games, your applauding by making a clucking sound with your lips. Anyone landing here, he says, knew at once he had not come to some city of Syria or of Cilicia.

Just north of you is the gate the Italians cut; the next track tells you when and why.

15 • The Small Citizenship

Liberty Gate (1924)

Stop under the arch, one foot in the medieval town and one on the pavement outside, because this opening is the seam between two cities and the seam has a date. The Italians cut it through the wall in nineteen twenty-four and named it the Gate of Liberty, for themselves, as the liberators of Rhodes from the Turks. Look through it. Across the road is a new town in red-orange fake stone imitating the masonry of the Knights, and the long low ring across the square, still closed for restoration, is the market that replaced the one inside the walls. All of it was built to organise the people behind you.

Italy landed at Kallithea Bay down the coast before dawn on the fourth of May, nineteen twelve, and marched into the walled town next morning through the Red Gate you passed by the Jewish quarter. The Greeks of ten islands met on Patmos that June and proclaimed a state of their own, hoping to join Greece, and were ignored. Italy called its stay provisional until a treaty of nineteen twenty-three made it permanent. The islands became a possession, neither a province nor a colony, one historian says: too far away to be Italy and too white, as the age put it, to be Africa. The town, by the census of nineteen twenty-two, was three big communities: six and a half thousand Muslims, five and a half thousand Orthodox and four thousand Jews.

So they sorted people. A decree of October nineteen twenty-five gave the islanders a citizenship of their own: you kept your personal law for marriage and inheritance, you owed no military service, and had no political rights or duties in Rome. People called it the small citizenship. The large kind was a reward for cooperating with the authorities, and without it you could not even join the Fascist Party; asked in nineteen twenty-nine whether islanders might join, Governor Lago judged the time unripe. Lago ran the place the Ottoman way, through communities: he kept the old civil code and the religious courts, let towns elect their own mayors, and encouraged Italians to marry local Greeks; the Church of Rhodes says a mixed marriage came with automatic conversion to

Catholicism and money to sweeten it. His successor, De Vecchi, tried to make Italians instead. In nineteen thirty-seven every mayor was replaced by an appointed podestà, and Italian took over the schools; Greek was optional, without books, and only for the youngest children. That spring De Vecchi banned the Venetokleion schoolboys' berets, and the police reported boys weeping and kissing the caps. When the headmaster ordered them to the fascist festival of the birthday of Rome in April, an eighteen-year-old stood up and asked, Mister Headmaster, did you not always tell us that we are Greeks? The headmaster was dismissed, seven boys arrested, three expelled from every school in the islands, and the school shut until nineteen forty-three.

Shopping was organised too. When the new market opened in nineteen twenty-six, the administration ordered every merchant still selling food inside the medieval town to leave at once; the Italian paper, the Messenger of Rhodes, explained that the old market was scattered through the walled city, impossible to inspect and short of water, and promised visitors in its place one of those characteristic oriental bazaars. So the farmers went outside the walls, the inside became a souvenir bazaar, and the street you climbed after lunch, and have just walked back down, is that decision, still running. And here is the part I like. A regime that claimed to have rescued Rhodes from five centuries of Ottoman rule restored more than thirty mosques and fitted out a working Turkish bath, ordering carpets and costume from Turkey, and insisting that at least two bath-masseurs, between twenty and fifty and in good moral and physical health, always be on hand. The tourists came to look, not to bathe. The Ottoman town was stripped inside the walls and restaged outside them as scenery.

Two years after the berets, the same administration raised two columns at the mouth of the harbour ahead of you and put a bronze stag and doe on top. Every age has decided for itself where the sun god's statue stood, and those columns are the answer the Italians built. Walk north along the water to them; that is where the fallen god gets measured.

16 • Measuring the God

The deer columns, Mandraki harbour mouth

Stand at the foot of one of the two columns and look across the water to the other. A bronze stag on one of them, a bronze doe on the other, sixty-two metres of harbour mouth between them. Every guide will tell you the Colossus stood with a foot on each. It did not; the columns simply stand where an old picture needs two feet.

The statue broke at the knees and lay where it fell for centuries, and the question is who came to look. Pliny says few men could get their arms round the thumb, which means men were trying: for three hundred years visitors hugged a fallen god to find out how big he was, and saw, where the limbs had broken, the rock inside that steadied him. Eight hundred years after the casting a writer who goes by the name of Philo was still measuring it on paper, five hundred talents of bronze and three hundred of iron, and said that on the earth a second sun now stood facing the first. By the late thirteen hundreds there was nothing left to see.

Then the camels. A medieval chronicler, writing of the year six hundred and fifty-three or four, has nine hundred of them carry the bronze away. Scholars do not believe the sale; notice only what the number is doing. Nine hundred camels at two hundred kilos each comes to something like a hundred and eighty tonnes, about a dozen times the bronze Philo says went into the statue. It is the last hug of the thumb: the god measured in the largest unit the teller owned.

Now back to the deer. Nobody has quite pinned down who put them up: a Rhodes newspaper says the Italians in nineteen thirty-nine, another account gives only a year, nineteen forty-seven, and no sculptor at all. What is certain is that a town which, in March nineteen forty-eight, raised the Greek flag in front of the fascist party house along this quay, the fascist symbols already chiselled off, the King looking on, and the building now its town hall, left the deer standing, and they are the island's badge now. Guides say deer were brought to Rhodes to drive out the snakes, on an oracle's advice or by the Knights. No ancient writer says so. One of the island's old names did mean snake island, and

Diodorus tells the ancient story plainly: the island crawled with snakes, an oracle of Apollo told the Rhodians to send for a Thessalian called Phorbas, and Phorbas killed the snakes, settled here, and after his death was honoured as a hero. The oracle that once sent for a hero now sends for a deer. The Rhodian fallow deer are real, and genetically a line of their own. So a town whose Greeks, three and a half centuries after the conquest, were still walking out of their own walled centre at sunset, took a small, gentle, native animal for its badge, and left it standing where the pagan giant was supposed to have straddled the harbour. Every age measures the Colossus with its own instruments and plants it where its own harbour is.

Now look at the water, because the water is what the Rhodians gave things to. A Roman dictionary-maker named Festus, explaining why Romans sacrificed a horse in October, reached for a foreign parallel: the Rhodians, who every year throw into the sea four-horse chariots consecrated to the Sun, because he is said to be carried round the world in such a chariot. That is the whole of it: no date, no colour of horses, not even whether it belonged to the Halieia, the city's games for the Sun. The rest you can work out for yourself: he goes down into this same sea every evening on the far side of this point, and climbs out of it every morning off the Turkish coast; once a year the city sent a chariot down into it after him.

A hundred and fifty metres back along the waterfront stands the church of the Annunciation, and on the sixth of January the town still walks from it to the water. In twenty twenty-five Metropolitan Kyrillos blessed the waters on a platform behind the church, and a young man named Michalis Mavridis came up with the cross; in January this year the programme had the Municipal Philharmonic and a detachment of soldiers walking with the cross from the church to the pier again. Nobody can show that one rite descends from the other. But it is the one ceremony left in which this town gives something to the sea and takes it back. The pattern survives; the god's name did not.

Now walk out along the mole to the fort, and at the end turn round and look back. The next track asks where you put a god.

17 • Where You Put a God

Fort St Nicholas, tip of the Mandraki mole

Stand at the end of the mole with the round fort at your back and the small closed harbour in front of you. Behind the fort, to the north across the strait, is the coast of Turkey. This is the traditional spot for the Colossus, and nobody knows. The better question is where a city puts its god.

Three places claim it: under this fort, on the acropolis hill to the southwest with the re-erected columns, and on the small hill under the Palace, where the Sun's priests left their dedications. Nobody has dug. But the two candidates scholars now favour, the Palace hill and the acropolis, share one assumption, and it is why they have left this mole: a votive belongs in the god's own precinct, and the precinct was an office. The priest of the Sun named the year on every decree and every wine jar. You put the god where his office was. The face you saw in the museum this morning, drilled round the brow for metal rays, is well over a century younger than the Colossus and from another statue, and nobody has published where it was found; it is still the closest you will come to the face they were buying.

Then there is the word. A kolossos, Nathan Badoud reminds us, was originally a magical figure, not defined by its size, that could hold a god or a mortal inside it. When Thera sent settlers to found Cyrene, so a later inscription says, the whole town, children included, watched wax kolossoi burn as the settlers swore never to abandon the colony, and cursed any oath-breaker to melt away like the wax. By the time Rhodes built hers the word already meant, plainly, a statue bigger than a man. One word for a wax figure burned in an oath and a bronze god the height of a ten-storey building.

Now the water in front of you. This was the closed war harbour; the big harbour where your ship lies was the open market. One basin for citizens with oars, one for foreigners with cargo. Some of the dockyards here were secret; to spy on them, or even to walk inside, was death. A trihemolia, the Rhodian pirate-hunter, carried a hundred and forty-four men, a

hundred and twenty of them at the oars. Diodorus counted six thousand citizens under arms in the siege; forty such ships would have swallowed most of them. That arithmetic explains Strabo's strangest line about Rhodes. The well-to-do fed the needy, he says, by an ancestral custom, so that the poor man receives his sustenance and the city does not run short of useful men, and in particular for the manning of the fleets. The custom ran on liturgies, public duties the rich paid for in person. Welfare as a naval budget wearing the clothes of charity. The families who captained the ships also held the priesthood of the Sun; Vincent Gabrielsen calls them the naval aristocracy of Rhodes.

That coast was theirs as well. The villages on the near shore were Rhodian demes; their people came over to hold priesthoods on this island; in one hundred and eighty-eight before Christ Rome handed Rhodes the mainland behind it, Caria and Lycia, then took it back twenty-one years later for staying neutral in the wrong war. Today that shore is Turkey, a ferry ride and a customs post away. The Sun ran their clock too: the Antikythera Mechanism has a dial of games, and in its fourth-year slot sits the Halieia, the games of the Sun; that spelling, Paul Iversen argues, is found almost nowhere but Rhodes, the first link in his case that the machine was made on this island.

The Knights built the fort over a chapel of Saint Nicholas, the sailors' patron. What ties it to the dead is fourteen eighty. After the failed assault, seven hundred bodies covered the rocks and the mole; the Turks were allowed to bury them in an immense pit facing the fort; the bones, uncovered shortly before eighteen eighty-one, were reburied in the Ottoman cemetery across the water. Count the guardians on this shore: Aphrodite at the little temple by Symi Square, Helios on this mole if he was ever here, Nicholas in the fort, and the Annunciation on the quay, behind which, every sixth of January, the cross goes into this harbour and the young men dive for it. Four guardians, one job.

Walk back along the mole, past the windmills, to the floating decks by the closed market; the next track there is about how a Greek celebrates, and who pays for it.

18 • Chronia Polla

Swan by Kontiki (floating bar, Mandraki)

Climb to the top deck and take a seat at the rail where you can see both the town quay beside you and, across the water, the windmills on the mole and the fort at its end. This is the stretch of waterfront where Rhodes comes out in the evening for its volta, the slow walk along the water at sundown, and you are here a few hours ahead of it. Today is Rob's birthday, and the first thing to know about a birthday in Greece is that it is the lesser feast.

The day that counts is the name day, the feast of the saint you were named for. Ask a Greek friend and they will tell you a name day matters more than a birthday, and matters more the older you get. The Church, for its part, treats a birthday as the anniversary of your arrival on earth and would rather you did not make a party of it. A name day runs the other way round from a birthday: nobody surprises you, because the calendar is public, and you are the one who does the giving. The house used to be simply open; lately the invitations go out first, but the shape has not changed. Friends and relatives come to wish you well and leave a small gift, and the one being celebrated does the feeding: coffee, sweets, drinks, whatever is on the table. The kerasma, the treat, comes from the celebrant. The wish is chronia polla, many years. Not happy birthday. Many years. So the rule for this deck is simple. Everyone says chronia polla, and Rob pays.

Names here are inherited more than chosen. The eldest grandson takes his grandfather's name, the eldest granddaughter her grandmother's, so the same saints come round through a family every second generation, and a family's calendar is really its tree. Someone named for a hero instead of a saint, an Achilleas, an Odysseas, has no name day at all and borrows All Saints' Sunday, the Sunday after Pentecost. And Rhodes has a name that exists nowhere else, because it is a vow. A woman who wants a child climbs, barefoot by most accounts, to the little chapel of the Virgin at Tsambika on the east coast, on the eve of the eighth of

September, a little over three weeks ago, and the child who follows is called Tsambikos or Tsambika. The name is the receipt.

And the thirtieth of September? It belongs to Gregory the Illuminator, the enlightener of Greater Armenia, and a few Armenian martyrs nobody in Greece is named for. A quiet day. Even Greeks called Grigoris keep their feast in January instead. Almost nobody in Greece has a name day today, which makes Rob, in Greek terms, about the only celebrant on the quay, and the treat is his.

Look down at the quay before you go. The Jewish museum remembers this waterfront, which it calls the square, as the place where in the Italian years the young of the quarter came to look at each other, “young men and women walking from one end of the square to the other, backwards and forwards, crossing and crisscrossing each other exchanging silent looks day after day.” That walk still happens along this water in the evening, and the ship sails before it begins, so you are seeing the town just before it comes out to look at itself.

Whenever you are ready, the way back is along this water, out past a gate named for Paul and the stump of a tower an earthquake took down in eighteen sixty-three, and the return track picks you up there.

19 • Who Ran the Island When

Naillac tower stump and St Paul's Gate

The broken stump out at the head of this mole, beside the harbour light, was a tower of the Knights. Look back along the mole to the bastion at its root: that is the Gate of Saint Paul, and your story starts there. On the tower over the gate the Knights set a relief of the apostle, sword in one hand and Gospel in the other, and the arms of Pope Sixtus the Fourth, the pope of the fourteen eighty siege: two carvings, one constitution. The Order ran this island as a sovereign state, a monastery with a mint and a fleet, but it answered to Rome: in thirteen nineteen the Pope unmade two Grand Masters and installed a third. The Acts of the Apostles say only that Paul's ship called at Rhodes; tradition, not the Bible, lands him at Lindos, in a bay below the altar where the sons of the Sun sacrificed without fire.

The last handover took five years. When Italy's armistice came in nineteen forty-three the Germans took the island within days, and the winter of nineteen forty-four to forty-five was famine, a catastrophe you will pass no monument to today. The bishop's first telegram for help went not to a government but to the Patriarch of Alexandria and the Archbishop of Athens: "The people of Rhodes in agreement with the Red Cross are agonizingly awaiting sacks of flour." Hunger sorted people by where they had kin: about four thousand of the nine thousand Dodecanese Muslims crossed to Turkey and were sent back in nineteen forty-five; Greeks who fled ended up in makeshift British refugee camps on Kasos and Karpathos. When the Germans surrendered, the British kept the Italian tax system, minus its fascist clauses, fed the town from Red Cross soup kitchens, and in the spring of nineteen forty-seven handed the island to a Greek rear admiral. On the seventh of March nineteen forty-eight the Greek flag went up in front of the Italian government buildings on Mandraki, with the King present, once the fasces and Mussolini's statues of Caesar and Octavian had been taken away. It is still a holiday across the Dodecanese, with a parade along the esplanade the Italians laid out for mass gatherings.

Every regime taxed the gangway. In one hundred and sixty-four before Christ the envoy Astymedes told the Roman Senate that the harbour dues, once farmed for a million drachmas, now fetched a hundred and fifty thousand, because Rome had made Delos a free port; a republic became a client. The Knights farmed their customs to the Genoese Tobias Lomelino, who bought the farm year after year in the fourteen seventies. The Ottomans sold the taxes to contractors who took back up to five times what they paid. And since July of last year every cruise passenger stepping ashore in Greece pays a landing levy, which the ship settles on your behalf every quarter.

If you want the whole history of who ran this island in two words, they are on a coin. After the Crusaders took Constantinople in twelve hundred and four, a local magnate named Leo Gabalas held Rhodes on his own account and struck coins that say Caesar on one face and servant of the emperor on the other. The republic of the sailors kept every king as a friend and none as a master; the Knights minted their own money and answered to the Pope; for three centuries the Ottoman governor here answered to the admiral of the fleet, and for most of four, as Tozer saw in eighteen eighty-six, the Greeks who kept the shops inside these walls were “obliged to quit the place at sunset”. Sovereign on one face, somebody’s servant on the other.

Four questions have followed you round the walls today: who decided, who paid, who could own, who could sleep inside. Every regime answered them differently, but the sharpest mark of belonging has always been the walled town after dark: a curfew bell and a lantern then, a resident’s car permit and a holiday flat’s registry number now. Walk back along the mole and round the quay. The ship is across the water from you, and its gangway is the last toll gate of the day.

20 • B-side: When the Island Breaks

Moat entrance at Mandraki (St Paul's Gate gardens)

Find a place on the floor of the ditch where you can see both walls at once, thirty metres of grass between them, and near you a stack of stone cannonballs. They have been ammunition, then rubble, then ornament, and now they are the one thing in this park nobody planted, and who stacked them is anyone's guess. About once a century this ground answers the same question: what happens when the island breaks.

The first break came nine months after the Ottoman siege lifted in August fourteen eighty. At three in the morning on the third of May fourteen eighty-one the shock came, a magnitude of about seven, enough to crack the Palace and to raise a small wave that still tore a large ship from its moorings; that ship, or another, later ran onto a reef and went down with all hands. The old catalogues say thirty thousand dead, a number nobody can check; the damage was real, and what you are standing in is the answer to it and to the siege before it: the ditch, the islands of earth and stone in it, the bastions above you, rebuilt between fourteen eighty-one and fifteen twenty. The Order of Saint John was, among other things, an insurance company. Its commanderies across Europe each sent a yearly remittance, the responsions; in thirteen twenty-nine the Venetian Marino Sanudo grumbled that an Order taking a hundred and eighty thousand florins a year from those alone could not put two or three galleys to sea. And the pope signed for his share: over Saint Paul's Gate, at the Mandraki end of this ditch, the arms of Sixtus the Fourth still sit beside the saint, as near as the Knights came to a donor's plaque.

The second break came twice in one autumn. The great Cretan earthquake of October eighteen fifty-six reached this island in the small hours; sixty people died here and the coastline lifted. Twenty-five days later lightning struck the bell tower of the old church of Saint John beside the Palace and fired a store of gunpowder in its cellars that the Ottoman authorities did not know about. At least two hundred died. The Ottoman answer was a school on the rubble, and the Palace, used for

a time as a convict prison, stayed a half-ruin for eighty years until the Italians rebuilt it; today the walls are kept up with European money.

This ditch has also held people. The Italians laid out these gardens where, the old accounts say, there had been orchards under both the Knights and the Turks, clearing the Ottoman graveyards that had grown up against the walls and, on the stretch ahead of you, the Jewish cemetery, whose families could move a grave if they could pay for it. The traveller Henry Tozer, walking here in eighteen eighty-six, saw a Turkish one just outside the moat, where, he wrote, lay the bones of the besiegers who fell during the siege; he can only mean fifteen twenty-two. After Italy attacked Greece in October nineteen forty, the Orthodox Metropolis of Rhodes records Greek-citizen teachers imprisoned in the old city moat, and a local history of the island says Governor De Vecchi kept a camp for Greek nationals in these trenches.

The oldest answer is the one Rhodes wrote down. In three hundred and five before Christ, before the great siege began, the assembly voted the terms in advance: public burial for anyone who fell, their parents and children maintained from the public treasury, their daughters given dowries at the public cost, and, in the historian Diodorus's words, to buy from their masters any slaves who proved themselves brave men in the battle, and to emancipate and enfranchise them. The ancient city drew the circle of who counted before the disaster, wide enough to take in its slaves. Every regime since has drawn it during the disaster: by which church you gave to, which passport you held, or, in the wildfires of two thousand and twenty-three, which hotel you had booked.

On the south-east stretch, between the Saint John bastion and the great round bastion at the harbour corner, the ditch opens into the Melina Mercouri theatre, where one August night the town put on a free evening of Manolis Chiotis's swing tunes. The siege ground is the town's living room now, and nobody sleeps in it against their will. The ditch ends either by the port, a few minutes from the ship, or at Mandraki under the pope's coat of arms.

21 • B-side: The Business of Strangers

Kallithea Springs (Thermes Kallitheas)

Stand in the small rotunda, the round pavilion with the six arched gates, and look out at the water. Italy landed on this beach at four in the morning on the fourth of May nineteen twelve, unopposed, and the town surrendered the next day. Seventeen years later the Italian governor built a spa on the site, and the King of Italy, Victor Emmanuel the Third, came to open it on the first of July nineteen twenty-nine. Together with the Hotel of the Roses on the town shore, now the casino, this was Italy bringing mass tourism to Rhodes. The spa's own history claims Hippocrates and Herodotus for its pedigree; treat that as advertising. And the historian Valerie McGuire adds a deflating detail: the water the visitors actually took was bottled nearby and drunk, which makes the little pool under the dome you are standing beneath mostly a photograph. Today the town hires the place out for weddings. So a beach where soldiers came ashore became a place people pay to lie down. That is the island's oldest business: taking strangers in.

It takes them in for talking, too. In January nineteen forty-nine the United Nations mediator Ralph Bunche, an American, opened the armistice talks between Egypt and Israel on Rhodes; the Hotel of the Roses says the agreement was signed under its roof, on the twenty-fourth of February. He won the Nobel Peace Prize for it, and twenty years later American and Soviet diplomats were still arguing over a Rhodes formula: a go-between, separate rooms to begin with, and one table once the parties were ready. Nothing could be more Rhodian. For nearly a hundred and forty years the ancient republic fought beside Rome and never signed a treaty with her, because, as Polybius puts it, they wished none of the kings and princes to despair of gaining their help and alliance, and so did not desire to run in harness with Rome. Neutrality was the product. Every king was a potential customer.

And when the money stops, the island takes people in for nothing. On the eighteenth of July twenty twenty-three a fire started above the village of Laerma and ran for a week towards the south-east coast. Within three

days there was a state of emergency, Laerma was emptied, and then the coast villages below it, Pefki, Lindos, Kalathos; by the end about nineteen thousand people had been moved, two thousand of them off the beaches by boat. The fire service called it the largest evacuation the island had ever seen. Where do nineteen thousand people sleep? This town alone has something like thirty thousand hotel beds. A hotel is a building designed to absorb strangers at scale, and in a crisis it is the spare room of the whole island; the Knights' hospital in the old town, this spa and the all-inclusive down the road are one trade. On the second of August the emergency was lifted and the Ministry of Tourism offered the evacuated visitors free accommodation. The visitors, notice. And eight years earlier, in April twenty fifteen, a migrant boat struck a reef off this same eastern shore with ninety-six people aboard. Three died. The other ninety-three were got out in shallow water, and the photographs the papers ran that week showed people from the shore standing waist-deep, passing survivors hand to hand.

The spa sold water. Last winter a hydrologist, Elisavet Feloni, told the island's newspaper that Rhodes has entered a water-alert zone, that demand, above all the tourists', now exceeds what the rain can give back, and almost no rain falls here in July, August or September, so you are standing at the driest point of the island's year, in a spa built to sell the stuff.

On the road back you will pass, in a row, a Catholic cemetery, a Muslim one and a Jewish one, planned from nineteen twenty-five by the architect who drew the Hotel of the Roses, with the Orthodox behind and the Commonwealth war cemetery across the road. The twentieth century sorted its dead by faith and by army: the Catholic ground keeps its soldiers in a half-circle of niches under one tall cross, and the war cemetery opposite took in sixty-five graves from Kos when that ground closed in nineteen fifty-seven; a hundred and forty-two lie there under the Commonwealth's care. Keep to the time you were given for the taxi; the next track, if you take it, waits on the hill above the town.

22 · B-side: Three Cities, One Contract

Summit of Monte Smith (Kebrić's site) and the nymphaea

You are standing by four columns on a ridge, and below you is the long straight of a stadium. Look north along the ridge to the summit, then east over the town to the two harbours. Everything between here and the water was one city laid out by agreement.

Diodorus gives the founding one sentence, under the year we call four hundred and eight before Christ: the people of the island left the cities of Ialysos, Lindos and Kameiros and settled in one city, the one now called Rhodes. Three separate states agreed to stop being three. The blocks were identical, three houses to each, drains underneath. Identical blocks mean allotment: three populations that had run their own affairs, measured out and mixed street by street.

Here is the trick. The three cities did not dissolve. They became the three tribes of the new state, Lindia, Kamiris and Ialysia, competing against each other at the festivals of the new capital. Under the tribes ran the demes, the villages, so a citizen was formally of such-and-such a village. Under the demes ran something older still, small units of land and their local rites, that the new system covered over but never abolished. Soon after three hundred and twenty-five before Christ the people of Kameiros resolved to carve the names of all their land-units on a stone in Athena's temple, the contractor chosen by lowest bid. So a household belonged at once to its plot and its local shrine, to its village for registration, to its tribe for priesthoods and games, and to the city for the assembly, the fleet and the law. Nested belonging, four layers deep. That is the invention, more than the grid.

Who decided, and who ate? Somewhere below you, never found, is the theatre where the assembly and the courts met. Cicero has Scipio describe the arrangement: the same men were senators and private citizens by turns, for certain months each, paid for both, and decided capital cases in the theatre and the council house alike. Strabo is blunt that the rule was not democratic, but by an ancestral custom the well-to-do supplied the poor with provisions, so that the city never ran short

of men to row. The navy was the welfare state. A rich man's duty was to feed rowers, and a poor man's was to row.

No ancient text names this track, but it is the stadium the city has, so picture the Sun's games, the Halieia, run here: the procession coming up from the town, the sacrifice, then the runners on this straight. The family to know is Diagoras of Ialysos, Olympic boxing champion in four hundred and sixty-four before Christ, whose three sons and two grandsons were all Olympic victors. When two of his sons won at Olympia on the same day, Cicero says, a Spartan came up to the old man and told him: die, Diagoras, for you are not going to climb up to heaven. His daughter Kallipateira went to Olympia disguised as a trainer to watch her son, was discovered, and, Pausanias says, was acquitted for the family's record, after which trainers had to strip too. Today the airport and one of the football clubs are named Diagoras.

One last pair. Around six hundred before Christ Cleobulus governed Lindos and left the maxim moderation is best. Athenaeus preserves a song Rhodian children sang from door to door, asking the rich house for cake, wine and cheese, threatening to carry off the door, or the little wife, if refused, and ending: now open, open the door for the swallow, we are not old men, but only children. Athenaeus says Cleobulus started the collection when there was need of money. Redistribution disguised as a game. His daughter Cleobulina made the wise men guess: I have seen a man with fire fasten bronze on another. A doctor's heated cupping glass. Plutarch's Thales says her father's rule grew milder because of her.

The municipality still publishes four hundred and eight before Christ as the city's birthday, so Rob is sharing his with it. From here you can see the small hill under the Palace, where the most recent book on the Colossus puts the Sun's sanctuary and his statue, though nobody has ever dug to check, and beyond it the harbour where the ship is waiting. That is the whole city you walked today, in one look.